CONCEPT PAPER

Title: Motivation and Persistence of Working Adult Learners in Online Graduate Courses: An Interview Study

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Background and Rationale

Working adults who enroll in graduate programs balance coursework with jobs and family duties. Academic motivation, burnout, and well-being affect whether they finish. Earlier studies of adult learners describe intrinsic motivation and support from instructors as reasons for persistence, but little is known about the experience of students in this university's online graduate courses.

Statement of the Problem

The study asks what motivates working graduate students to persist in online courses, and what makes them consider stopping.

Objectives

1. Describe the motivations of working graduate students in online courses. 2. Identify the stresses that lead to burnout or to dropping a course. 3. Recommend supports the Graduate School can provide.

Methodology

The study uses a qualitative case study design. Data collection is through semi-structured interviews with twelve graduate students. The interview transcripts will be coded by theme using an audit trail so that the procedure can be checked.

Significance and Scope

The results can help the Graduate School plan advising and support services for working students. The scope is limited to one college and one academic year.

References

Deci, E., and Ryan, R. (2000). The what and why of goal pursuits: human needs and self-determination. Kasworm, C. (2010). Adult workers as undergraduate students: significant challenges for higher education policy and practice. Schaufeli, W., et al. (2002). Burnout and engagement in university students.